control of the majority of the subcontinent throughout India's Middle Ages, with Persian functioning as their common language.

One of the most notable sultans of this particular dynasty was Razia Sultana, the only female to hold such a title during the entire three-century span of the Delhi Sultanate. A granddaughter of Qutb al-Dīn Aibak, Razia was a favorite child of her father, Iltutmish, and the latter granted her power of succession when her eldest brother died. Being a sultan was not an easy role for a woman due to the hatred Razia faced from the men in her own army and among her own brothers.

The Sultanate was a purely patriarchal society, and Razia's rise to the throne was completely unprecedented. To try to overcome the negativity, Razia dressed in the clothes of a man while leading the army to confront her usurper brother, Muiz ud-Din Bahram, in Delhi in 1240. She was killed by her own turncoat military generals who had been loath to follow the commands of a woman.

In 1290, Jalal-ud-din Khalji established the successor to the Slave Dynasty: the Khalji Dynasty. By this time, the kingdom stretched all the way westward to the Arabian Sea and almost down to the southernmost tip of the subcontinent. Further conquest was not the most pressing issue facing the sultans of the Khalji Dynasty, however, since they were busy keeping the Mongols out of their territory. Under the leadership of Genghis Khan, the fearsome Mongol army began to forcefully press its way through China, Afghanistan, and the Turkic countries of the Middle East. Repeatedly, Khan's and eventually his successor's armies tried to vanquish India, but the vast lands of the Sultanate remained untouched by Mongol hordes—except for a portion of Punjab. The attacks began in 1222 and did not cease until 1327.

The constant need for military might during that century all but exhausted the Sultanate's resources. Sultan Alauddin Khalji, therefore, completely reorganized the kingdom's taxation system in the early 14th century, raising agriculture taxes from 20 percent to 50 percent and cutting the salaries of administrative officials. He was also forced to cut the salaries of government-sponsored poets and scholars. In addition to these measures, Alauddin placed a heavy financial burden on the members of his kingdom who did not conform to his religion, Islam.